driving the various ethnic conflicts in northern Myanmar.[113] A wider issue is that it is often Chinese-funded investment projects fuelling local disputes about land ownership across Myanmar,[114] in effect destabilising the very regime China relies on to safeguard its investments. Both the recent conflict involving the Kachin and an escalation of tension in the Shan region are connected to major Chinese infrastructure projects. China seems to be playing favourites among the armed groups in the region as it seeks to safeguard its border, its investments, and the transport links being developed from China to the Bay of Bengal. In an echo of the 'Burma Road' used to send supplies to China during World War II,[115] Myanmar is now seen by China 'as the bridge to the Bay of Bengal and the waters beyond'.[116] From this point of view, the only reason China might worry about the persecution of the Rohingyas is if the situation threatens their commercial interests.

More widely, China has been described as the 'elephant in the room'[117] with a 'firm reach into almost all corners of Myanmar society'.[118] Practically, the Chinese appear to strongly support the military rulers and have no reason to support democratic change. However, recently, they have started to court the NLD and they invited Aung San Suu Kyu to Beijing in July 2015.[119] This may have been a pragmatic preparation for the outcome of the November 2015 elections. China now has long-term interests in Myanmar, as creating the necessary transport infrastructure in the country would allow it to link landlocked provinces such as Yunnan to the sea.[120] Safeguarding these projects is probably of more importance to the Chinese than the actual make up of the government in Myanmar—as long as that government can deliver the required level of security.

Elsewhere, authoritarian regimes have found China a willing partner when they wish to avoid Western pressure around human rights and corruption.[121] This matters, as US–Chinese dynamics are becoming increasingly important for the future of Myanmar. If both China and the US perceive themselves to be in a zero-sum game for influence, this will dampen either state's willingness to really challenge the regime over human rights abuses[122] for fear that the other power will step into the vacuum. There is evidence that the US is more than prepared to do a deal with the existing military in return for vague promises of reform.[123] The US wants listening bases along the Andaman Sea, while China's expansion into this